well as alarming the US and other Western countries which saw a nexus between the Al Qaeda and the Pakistani Taliban that was considered a threat to them and to Pakistan's existence. TTP claimed that they had come into existence due to the US invasion of Afghanistan. Lieutenant General (r) Rashid Aziz, a close cohort of General Pervez Musharraf, stated in a TV interview that Pakistan started massacre of Muslims at the behest of the US, due to which terrorism broke out in Pakistan (*Dawn*, 2013).

THE FOUR FACTORS

In this outcry against Al Qaeda and its local allies, at least four aspects figured prominently as the basis of the new menace:

(1) Sectarian/Jihadi parties;
(2) FATA;
(3) Madrasah;
(4) Afghanistan.

The perceptions and realities about these four factors are addressed below before discussing the actual threats, that is, Al Qaeda, Taliban and TTP.

Sectarian/jihadi parties

The jihadi and sectarian parties that were instrumental in different phases of extremism, violence and terrorism in Pakistan have been discussed at length in the previous chapters. Many rudderless activists of proscribed organisations like LeJ, JeM, HM, SSP and LeJ joined the militants in FATA and Swat and indulged in militancy and terrorism. In fact, in character, they were flexible like Al Qaeda. In case of state pressures and bans, they adopted one form or the other to avoid annihilation and kept demonstrating their extremist tactics.

FATA

It was only after 2001 that FATA started earning the notoriety of a safe haven for all sorts of Islamist militants: local, regional and international. At the end of 2007, Director CIA Michael Hayden described Al Qaeda safe havens in FATA as a 'clear and present danger' to the US. The Director FBI also expressed similar sentiments. As surmised by Michael Mullen, Chairman of